

POLLUTION OF TARANAKI COASTLINE

Since returning to the department I have enquired amongst my colleagues as to the cause of the pollution off the Taranaki coastline that you were concerned about.

It appears that pollution of the North Taranaki coastline has been a matter of concern to local Maoris for decades. In essence the reefs adjacent to the mouth of the Waitara river, which are a traditional source of seafood for the Te Atiawa tribe, became progressively polluted over the years as a consequence of discharge of untreated Borough sewage and freezing works wastes directly into the river.

An 1100 meter ocean outfall constructed in the late 70's has not proved entirely satisfactory as water currents have tended to sweep the wastes back inshore again. There is also further concern (although not necessarily well-founded) that petrochemicals waste from the Synfuels and Petrolgas plants, although treated, might add to the pollution. However, I have not been able to find any justification for the view that waste from the IWD plant (or IWD dumpsites) has caused any significant pollution of the local coastline.